

## 4.3 Organising Data Into Levels

Large spreadsheets can be cumbersome, partly because of the scrolling involved to get to the desired location. Excel has tools to Go To a particular cell quickly, and allows freezing windows so it is possible to keep sight of important figures while scrolling to a different loca-



The “Go To Special” options

tion. Adding to these features that ease the management of large spreadsheets is the concept of Levels. You can see how useful this feature is by comparing it to the tree listing of Folders in the Windows Explorer Folder Pane: you can expand the listing of the drives in the system to reveal the top levels folder in the drive. Those Folders, which in turn contain other folders, have a “+” next to their folder icon. Clicking on the “+” will cause the node to expand to reveal the folders under it. This continues until the “+” mark in the node is replaced with a “-”, which signifies that there are no further nested folders in that node. Clicking on the “-” causes the node to roll up the listing of folders under it.

To make a large block of data manageable, Excel allows you to select cell ranges in it and mark them as groups. Groups are like folders in the Windows Explorer tree listing; they can be expanded or collapsed with a single click. Remember that the cells forming a Group need not meet any criteria, and need not share a common feature.

Groups can be created horizontally or vertically. If you’re doing Vertical Grouping, a scenario similar to the Windows Explorer Folder Pane is created, with a pane appearing on the left margin containing the “+” and “-” controls. If you’re doing Horizontal Grouping, a pane appears on the top and the nodes